Three Mistakes Families Make When They Plan Ahead for Mom's Care

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the easier habit.

Families with time to plan tend to trip in the same three places. Each one comes from wanting to do right by Mom, and each has an easier habit to put in its place.

1 Deciding where Mom will live before anything requires it

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Mom is well, and there is already a short list of places and a favorite among them. Or the opposite: the whole subject is closed, because talking about it feels like deciding it.

WHY IT HAPPENS Choosing feels like being responsible, and a building is easier to picture than a list of small jobs. But how much care a person needs varies from person to person and often changes over time, which makes today's guess a thin thing to rest a decision on. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Sort every suggestion into preparation, which helps whatever happens, and decisions, which would commit Mom to something. Do the first kind. Write the second kind down as things the family has chosen to wait on, and ask Mom what she wants. AARP's planning guide says a plan should never be made without the participation, knowledge and consent of the person it's about. [2]

2 Leaving the preparation to one person

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE One of you has the folder, makes the calls and remembers the dates. Everyone else says “just tell me what you need,” and means it.

WHY IT HAPPENS Preparation looks like one big job, so it goes to whoever lives closest or started first. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that siblings may assume that person has everything covered, and so don't see what has been added. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Break the preparation into pieces small enough for an afternoon, and note which could be done from out of town. Then ask directly and specifically for what's realistic. AARP's guide says team members need not all live nearby or have huge blocks of time to be of value. [3] [2]

3 Writing a plan nobody has a reason to open again

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A good family conversation, a tidy page of notes, a folder in a drawer. A year on, nobody can say what was agreed or whether it still fits.

WHY IT HAPPENS Finishing the page feels like finishing the job, and with Mom well, nothing on the calendar makes anyone look again. The Family Caregiver Alliance says the same of family meetings: they are not a one-time event. [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write a date for the next look on the page itself, and under it a few everyday changes that would bring the family back sooner. The CDC's advice for a care plan is to update it every year, or more often if the person's health or medicines change. [5]

The habit behind all three

Get things ready, with Mom and with each other, and write down when you'll look again. Leave the decisions that aren't due for the day they are.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say where Mom should live, who in your family should do what, or which changes should bring you back to the plan. It names three habits, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three habits to swap, and what goes in place of each. The next useful thing is a clear picture of today to plan from, and the care interview gives you one: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The advice credited to an organization comes from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
5. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan